

HOUSE BILL 63

By Cepicky

AN ACT to amend Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 5;
Title 9; Title 13 and Title 71, Chapter 5, relative to
housing programs.

BE IT ENACTED BY THE GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE:

SECTION 1. Tennessee Code Annotated, Title 71, Chapter 5, is amended by adding
the following as a new part:

71-5-1601.

There is created the Housing Opportunity and Pathways to Education (HOPE)
pilot program. The purposes of the pilot program are to:

- (1) Support homeless families and those at risk of homelessness;
- (2) Develop a comprehensive support system to transition families from
street-level homelessness to stable, permanent housing;
- (3) Partner with local nonprofit organizations to address the housing,
educational, healthcare, economic, and community integration needs of
participants in the program; and
- (4) Coordinate services for participants from the various federal, state,
and local entities that support homeless families.

71-5-1602.

The Tennessee housing development agency shall develop and manage the
HOPE pilot program.

71-5-1603.

The Tennessee housing development agency shall establish a facility in each county in which the HOPE pilot program is implemented. The facility must include space for:

- (1) A clinic for health appointments, including mental health and therapy;
- (2) A community room for supportive meetings;
- (3) Classrooms for adult learning programs;
- (4) Tutoring rooms for children; and
- (5) A child-safe room.

71-5-1604.

(a) The Tennessee housing development agency shall:

- (1) Hire skilled, clinically licensed social workers for case management;
- (2) Develop eligibility requirements for participants;
- (3) Develop an application form; and
- (4) Create four (4) levels of graduated services to be provided to

participants based on need and each participant's progress through the program.

(b) The levels of services created pursuant to subdivision (a)(4) must include,

but are not limited to:

(1) Level one:

- (A) Assistance with obtaining identification documentation;
- (B) Food and clothing assistance;
- (C) Creation of an extreme weather plan for the participant;
- (D) Provision of mail services;
- (E) Access to a locker, shower, and laundry facilities;
- (F) Access to a mobile clinic for primary care, mental health care, dental care, and vision care;

(G) Contacts for legal aid services; and

(H) Voluntary child placement;

(2) Level two:

(A) Provision of transitional housing, including pet-friendly housing;

(B) Community participation;

(C) Food and clothing assistance;

(D) Life coaching;

(E) Transportation;

(F) Access to a mobile clinic for primary care, mental health care, dental care, and vision care; and

(G) Voluntary child placement;

(3) Level three:

(A) Supportive housing;

(B) Community participation;

(C) Food and clothing assistance;

(D) Life coaching;

(E) Transportation;

(F) Employment assistance;

(G) Established primary care; and

(H) Reintegration with children, if placed in some other custodial environment, with educational support; and

(4) Level four:

(A) Stable, permanent housing;

(B) Establishment of an escrow account;

- (C) Community participation;
- (D) Food and clothing assistance;
- (E) Life coaching;
- (F) Transportation;
- (G) Employment assistance and job training;
- (H) Mental health services;
- (I) Continued health care;
- (J) An education plan; and
- (K) Reintegration with children, if placed in some other custodial environment, with educational support.

71-5-1605.

Subject to appropriations, the Tennessee housing development agency shall provide grants to local nonprofit organizations for participation in the HOPE pilot program.

71-5-1606.

(a) Upon receipt of a completed application form, the Tennessee housing development agency shall determine if the applicant meets the eligibility requirements within five (5) business days.

(b) Once an applicant has been accepted for participation in the HOPE pilot program, each state and local entity and each participating nonprofit organization shall respond to requests for services from the Tennessee housing development agency within five (5) business days of the request.

71-5-1607.

(a) The Tennessee housing development agency shall, in coordination with the department of safety, establish a streamlined identification documentation process for participants in the program.

(b) A participant in the program may use the address of the central program facility as the participant's official address for purposes of acquiring identification documentation for the duration of the participant's involvement in the program.

(c) The Tennessee housing development agency shall assign a post office box within the central program facility for each participant in the program if the participant is using the central program facility as an address.

(d) Central program facility staff shall assist participants in gathering and verifying necessary documentation for obtaining identification.

(e) A designated liaison at the central program facility shall oversee the identification documentation application process, ensuring all applications are complete and accurate before submission.

(f) If additional documentation is required, the liaison shall assist participants in obtaining the necessary documents promptly.

(g) Central program facility staff shall maintain records of all identification documentation applications and follow up on any pending or delayed applications.

71-5-1608.

The pilot program created pursuant to this part expires July 1, 2030.

71-5-1609.

This part applies in a county with a population of not less than one hundred thousand (100,000) and not more than one hundred one thousand (101,000), according to the 2020 or a subsequent federal census.

SECTION 2. This act takes effect upon becoming a law, the public welfare requiring it.